

The Five Core Values and Comparative Analysis of a Presence Driven Spirituality and Ecclesiology

Draft
Preston Graham Jr.

A Preliminary observation: The following five core values each complement the others and are even mutually dependent in many ways. They are all derived from a Redemptive Historical Analysis of Mediated Presence as related to participating in the gospel vis-à-vis a “temple” context of “presence.” In short, what would it mean to have a Christ centered, Christ mediated Spirituality as per his redemptive purpose (High Gospel) and his mediated presence (High Church) If the first two core values express the eschatological aspects of our theology (telos), the second three core values express the Christological aspects (Prophetic, Priestly, Kingly) of our theology. The church then is “Christology Applied To Eschatology.”

High Gospel Spirituality

Gospel Driven:

According to the gospel, *God is glorified in all things through Jesus Christ* (1 Peter 4:11). This means that the focus of everything we say and do is *not* on what WE must do in order to glorify God in order to gain God’s favor, but on what CHRIST has done on our behalf and received by faith alone in order to gain God’s favor. It sets us free from the fear of God’s condemnation and rejection and makes it “safe” to be morally flawed and spiritually broken. More than a message, the gospel is the life transforming power of God! It is quite simply an amazing grace that changes everything! A Gospel driven spirituality will have a high view of the “law of Christ” in relation to setting us free from idols of our own destruction, without being “law reliant” in so far as the basis of our being in God’s favor is not by our “works of the law” but by “Christ’s works of the law on our behalf.”

Reference paper: *The Centrality of the Gospel*, Tim Keller

Missional Centered:

The missional centered church is the church *in the world, not of the world and for the world* and with a particular interest in the issues facing a “post-Christian (vs. Christendom) oriented culture. A missional centered core value will want to emphasize the *missionary* nature of the church over against the church that does “missions.” Less viewed as “doing” evangelism in “obedience” to a command, it is the result of being transformed by the gospel, in both individual and communal ways such as to produce a kind of “*radioactive fallout which is not lethal but life-giving.*” (Leslie Newbigin, *The Gospel in a Pluralistic Society*) The missional centered church is particularly interested in the missional nature of God acting in, with and through the local church. It is related to God’s missional presence as mediated through the church, even as to partake (our sacramental value) in the Trinitarian conception of God. A missional idea of life takes seriously, and even quite literally, Christ’s statement: “Just as the Father sends me, so I send you” (John 20:21). Said in the context of the promised Holy Spirit, interpreted through the event of the Pentecost, the advent of the Holy Spirit in the three marks of the church (see below) means that the church is not merely the source of witness, it is the locus of witness in the world. The miracle of incarnation in Christ is spiritually taking place at the Lord’s table with Christ’s assembly, even as to allow Christ’s assembly to be Christ mediated in the world in mission. And this again changes everything! We will have a spirituality and ecclesiology that wants to do all things as if our neighbors and the world is present—a more “public, “in the midst of” way of thinking about our individual spirituality and the church!

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Reference Paper(s): *The Missional Church*, Tim Keller (c.f., *Doxological Evangelism*, Tim Keller, D. Guder, "The Church as Missional Community", Lesslie Newbigin, "The Congregation as Hermeneutic to the Gospel", *Gospel in a Pluralistic Society*)

High Church Spirituality

Confessional Centered

A *confessional centered* ministry is characterized by a church whose identity is most essentially "what it believes" and whose beliefs drives "what it does." The confessing church embodies the ancient saying, *Let the Redeemed of the Lord say so...* (Ps.107:2) Not to be confused with "traditionalism," a confessional identity must be rediscovered every generation anew and afresh in continuity with the confessional discovery in ages past and in service to the gospel, lest it become either "dead orthodoxy" or "mean spirited orthodoxy." Not to be confused with any one view of subscription (E.g. One could hold to a "good faith" approach to confessionalism for confessional reasons). The confessing church is capable of being strategically progressive and theologically serious and thoughtful, even "nuanced," out of the depth of theological reflection. As a result, the confessional centered church is nothing short of invigorating, as people discover themselves within a long history of self-discovery being rooted and grounded in the faith! A confessional centered spirituality will be less inclined to be "tossed to and fro by every wind of doctrine... being rooted and grounded in Christ." Christ is present and makes himself known in, with and through the corporate consensus of the church by means of her creeds and confessions. Thus, we will maintain a high value for Biblical/Theological training and expository sermons.

Reference paper(s) : *Creed or Chaos?... Why It Really Does Matter What You Believe* by Dorothy Sayers (c.f. Richard Lints, *Fabric of Theology*, Chapter 9, "From Theological Framework to Theological Vision) Samuel Miller, *Subscription* (pp. 5-72)

Sacramental Centered:

At the core of being sacramental is a worship driven life and spirituality—one that is informed and experienced after the sacramental principle itself. Namely, that *Worship* is an essential, even defining characteristic of the church hardly needs defending. Our identity as "church" is one of holy catholic and apostolic *assembly* in the sacramental *presence* of God and organically united with the church of every age and place. It is something we do with the glorious festal gathering of the saints and angels in heaven according (Hebs. 12:22-29). And at the heart of worship is the idea of being completed by our union with Christ by mystical presence of Christ in the Holy Spirit vis-à-vis the means of grace in and through the church. Life and worship then become a faithful human response to divine revelation and presence set into a dialogical pattern for the glory of God and human salvation! As summarized by Ralph Martin "the two beat rhythm of God's approach to us that meets with and evokes a reacting offering of ourselves to him seems basic to the Christian view of worship." Worship as such IS a participation (koinonia) in the sacramental presence of God, wherein it can be said with John Calvin that "no extent of space interferes with the boundless energy of the Spirit which transfuses life into us from the flesh of Christ." We believe in the real, albeit spiritual mystical presence of Christ wherein in the worship centered life we are "partakers of the divine nature" (2Pet.1:4) Here again, this changes everything! A sacramental spirituality will emphasize our union with Christ as the basis for our hope. This means that in worship and life, Christ completes our insufficient works and zeal

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as to keep us in God's perfect favor! IF we begin and end God's favor predicated upon justification (the forensic aspect of atonement), we "work out" our favor with God in union with Christ who completes us daily to the praise of God's glorious grace!

Reference Paper(s): *A Sacramental Theology of the Gospel*, by Preston Graham, James Torrance, *Worship, Community and Triune God of Grace* (Chapter 1-3), Preston Graham, *Priest With No Name* (The case for a "priestly" pastoral theology)

Communal Centered:

Christ final prayer for the church is perhaps more profound than we might immediately think. He prayed, *that they may be one as we are one*. (John 17:11) Notice that this unity is theologically grounded in the Trinitarian reality of the mystical union enjoyed within the Trinity, now being extended to include the members of the church. Again, Christ says, *"I in them, and You in Me; that they may be made perfect in one, and that the world may know that You have sent Me, and have loved them as You have loved Me... And I have declared to them Your name, and will declare it, that the love with which You loved Me may be in them, and I in them."* (John 17:23, 26) In sum, as based on our already *real albeit spiritual* union in Christ, true unity is the basis of a love oriented way of life, both related to individuals and corporate bodies. For instance, the Bible is literally packed with an ethics of "one anothering" love! This is to say that true Christian spirituality is never isolated from a corporate spirituality. True Christian ethics is never isolated from a corporate ethic. For instance, we will want to encourage a kind of process for making decisions about our use of time, money and resources that considers the interest of others, especially those with whom we share Christ! True love would mean that we would not want to traffic any information about others (even if we believed it was true) that would in any way harm their reputation or identity in the world. It would mean that we desire to bear one another's burdens in both outward and inward ways—through holistic love in practical ways and through praying with and for one another. To be a church of "one-anothering" means that we assume the privilege of sharing our lives with one another, in all the many ways that this will result in a willingness to both receive and give services of love—knowing that it is even the final apologetic and ultimate hermeneutic that God has given to the world in order that it might know Jesus Christ, in the flesh, even as this is presently being mediated through "one-anothering." Finally, a communal centered church will desire a multi-traditional (as to preserve confessionalism) and sacramental based (as to express our already unity in so far as we mystically partake together of Christ body and blood, albeit spirituality mediated by the Holy Spirit). Such a vision for unity will seek after a kind of union, even organic union, in a way that avoids the imperial, pragmatic and/or compromising tendencies in ecumenism in ages past (see below). And such a union will need to start at the local level and in concrete ways that go beyond even mere cooperatives in ministry but are expressed in conciliar and sacramental ways.

Reference Paper(s): Richard Hayes, *Ecclesiology and Ethics- In I Corinthians*, James Torrance, *Eldership*, Lesslie Newbigin, *Ecumenical Amnesia*.

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A Comparative Analysis:

Paradigms of Spirituality and Their Related Ecumenical Visions

Paradigms in Spirituality

Liberal Spirituality Communal Oriented Low Church/Low Gospel	Modern Evangelical Spirituality Confessional Oriented Low Church/High Gospel
Sacerdotal Spirituality Sacramental Oriented High Church/Low Gospel	Classical-Evangelical Spirituality Sacramental Communal Confessional High Church/High Gospel

4 Spiritualities:

#1. High Gospel, Low Church

Very individualistic with a stress on personal conversion and piety. Tends to be the more evangelical churches—pragmatic, memorialist and non-efficacious understanding of sacraments, band and bible oriented worship (revivalistic), Non-denominational (non-confessional). The so called “para-church church” or para-church—low view of membership..

#2. Low Gospel, High Church

This spirituality tends to lose the individual in conversion for the corporate. The Gospel is synonymous with church ritual. Historically described as “sacerdotalism,” this spirituality will see the ministry of the church as efficacious without qualification—e.g. baptismal regeneration, absolution, etc. One can be a committed participant in the church but have little personal experience with the transforming power of the gospel. Various types of church could fit this description-- Could be confessional but not missional, sacramental but not gospel centered...

3. Low Gospel, Low Church

Sometimes described as nominalism and is often associated with liberalism, this spirituality is often communal focused, albeit mostly horizontal (between humanity) such as to lose something of the vertical dynamic of communion as accomplished supernaturally by Christ acting in, with and through the Holy Spirit in the church. The “gospel” as such tends to be political/social vs. evangelical.

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4. High Gospel, High Church

This spirituality seeks to integrate all five dynamics together. As it will emphasis both an individual and corporate conversion (e.g “Repent (individual aspect) and be baptized”(corporate aspect). It will emphasis both word and deed: A holistic spirituality. It will think of atonement in both forensic (justification) and mystical (union with Christ) terms unto salvation. It will seek after a multi-traditional (as to preserve high church) and councilar/jurisdictional ecumenism vis-à-vis the missional nature of the church in Christ. *This is a typically classical/ancient form of spirituality.*

Paradigms in Ecumenism

Low Church, Low Gospel <i>Compromise</i> (WCC) Mono-Traditional/Blended Ecumenical	Low Church, High Gospel <i>Pragmatic</i> (Modern Evangelical) Non-Traditional/Non-Ecumenical Cooperatives/Networks
High Church, Low Gospel <i>Imperial</i> (RC) Mono-Traditional/Schismatic	High Church, High Gospel <i>Classical Evangelical</i> (Newbigin) Multi-Traditional/Missional

The Fourth Way Illustrated:

For the perfecting of the life of the whole body, the Church of South India needs the heritage of each of the uniting Churches, and each of those Churches will, it is hoped, **not** lose the continuity of its own life, but preserve that life enriched by the union with itself of the other two Churches. The Church of South India is thus formed by a combination of different elements each bringing its contribution to the whole, and **not** by the absorption of any one by any other. It is, therefore, also a comprehensive Church; and its members, while firmly holding the fundamentals of the faith and order of the Church Universal, are allowed wide freedom of opinion in all other matters, and wide freedom of action in such differences of practice as are consistent with the general framework of the Church as one organized body.

Lesslie Newbigin *The Unity that We Seek*,

- Organic/Councilar (Communal) vs. Invisible
- Multi-Traditional (Confessional) vs. compromise
- Sacramental Jurisdiction (Sacramental) vs. pragmatic
- Missional Gospel vs. socio-political gospel